✈️ Travelling in Europe in 2026: Get Ready for the New Border

Remember when travelling to Europe simply meant **getting to the airport**, showing your passport and hoping you hadn't forgotten your toothbrush? Things **have changed**. Europe now **has** a new digital border system, and if you are travelling from outside the EU, it is worth knowing what to expect. The new **Entry/Exit System (EES)** became fully operational across the Schengen Area on 10 April 2026. Instead of simply getting a stamp **in your passport**, many non-EU visitors on short stays now **get their entry and exit recorded digitally**. The system can record passport information, a facial image and fingerprints.

So, before you **get on** that plane, here is what you need to know.

The airport experience is getting more digital

Most travellers **usually arrive at** the airport two or three hours before an international flight. They **check in**, **go through** security and then spend far too much money **on** coffee while waiting **at** the gate.

But border control **is changing**.

If you are a non-EU national visiting the Schengen Area for a short stay, your entry **may involve** a biometric check. The first time you use the system, you might **get asked** to provide fingerprints and have your face scanned.

Don't **get nervous** if it takes a little longer. Millions of travellers **have already used** the new system, and the idea is that digital records will eventually make border checks more efficient.

Imagine this:

"Why is that machine taking a picture of me? I've just **got off** a six-hour flight and I look terrible!"

Unfortunately, the border computer probably doesn't care.

What has happened to passport stamps?

For many short-stay visitors, EES **has replaced** traditional passport stamping with digital records of when they enter and leave the Schengen Area. This also makes it easier to keep track **of** the 90-days-in-180-days rule.

Perhaps you **have visited** Europe many times and **have collected** passport stamps for years. That little collection **is disappearing**, but at least you won't have to **worry about** an immigration officer putting a stamp directly over your favourite one.

If you hold a long-stay visa or a residence permit from a country operating EES, however, you are generally exempt from EES registration.

And what about ETIAS?

You may also have heard **about** ETIAS. Don't get the two systems mixed up.

EES is a **border registration system**. ETIAS will be a **travel authorisation** for visa-exempt travellers before travelling to Europe.

As of September 2026, ETIAS **has not started operating yet**. The EU says it is expected in the last quarter of 2026, but the precise starting date has not yet been announced.

So if somebody tells you, "You must apply for ETIAS today!", **be sceptical about** it and check the official EU website first.

ETIAS **is going to become** another thing travellers need to think about, but you **might not need** to do anything yet.

How to avoid getting into trouble

Modern travel is easier when you **get organised** before leaving home.

Make sure your passport is valid, check the entry requirements **for** your destination and **look into** anything that applies specifically to your nationality. You should also **get to** the airport with enough time to deal with unexpected queues.

If you **are travelling** during a busy holiday weekend, give yourself even more time. A ten-minute delay **at** security can suddenly turn **into** a 45-minute queue.

And don't be the person running **through** the terminal shouting:

"WAIT! I'M COMING!"

The plane **will not wait** for you.

If everything goes according **to** plan, though, you **will get through** the airport, **get on** your flight and finally **get to enjoy** your holiday.

Travel technology **has changed dramatically in recent years**, and borders **are becoming** increasingly digital. Some people **might find** the new systems annoying at first, while others **will appreciate** having fewer passport stamps and more automatic checks.

Either way, the message is simple:

Get informed, get organised, get to the airport early — and then get away from it all.